



Introduction – “Prayer, the First Resort”

“Be careful for nothing; but in every thing by prayer and supplication with thanksgiving let your requests be made known unto God.” — Philippians 4:6 (KJV)

Life will try to rush you. Stress will try to speak first. Fear will try to grab the microphone. But Philippians 4:6 gives us a different plan: **pray first**. Prayer isn’t what you do after you’ve tried everything else—it’s the **first resort** that walks you into God’s presence before anxiety walks you into panic.

Prayer isn’t a religious routine or “pretty words.” It’s real communication with a real God. You’re not informing Him—He already knows. You’re inviting Him into the center of your thoughts, your decisions, your relationships, your pressure, and your future. Prayer is how you stop carrying everything alone and start moving with faith.

This month, we’re learning prayer through four real-life examples that match what you’re facing right now:

- **Esther** — Don’t rush it; pray and fast first, then move with courage.
- **Solomon** — When God says “Ask,” don’t chase stuff—ask for wisdom.
- **Jesus** — God honors consistent communication with Him.
- **Paul & Silas** — Your present circumstances don’t have to define you; prayer and praise break chains.

So as we start Month 1, let prayer be your first escort—before the group chat, before the breakdown, before the plan. Because when you learn to pray first, you don’t just get answers... you get **peace, direction**, and a stronger walk with God.

SOUL FOOD BIBLE STUDY

Breakfast Edition Month 1 – Esther

Second *IS* the Best

 **Theme:** God can use you even when you feel like the “backup plan.”

 **Background Text:** Esther 1–4 (focus on chapters 2–4)

 **Key Verse: Esther 4:14 (WEB)**

“For if you remain silent now, then relief and deliverance will come to the Jews from another place, but you and your father’s house will perish. **Who knows if you haven’t come to the kingdom for such a time as this?**”

 Appetizer – Esther’s Unexpected Crown, Esther 2:17 (WEB)

“The king loved Esther more than all the women, and she obtained favor and kindness in his sight more than all the virgins; so that he set the royal crown on her head, and made her queen instead of Vashti.”

Esther didn’t grow up dreaming of being queen. She was a Jewish orphan, raised by her cousin Mordecai, living in a foreign empire. But when Queen Vashti was removed, a search went out—and Esther was chosen. People might’ve seen her as “second pick,” but God saw her as **perfectly placed**.

 **Reflection Question**

Have you ever felt like you were only chosen because someone else messed up or said no?

Main Course

Bite 1 – A Scary Choice, Esther 4:13–14 (WEB)

“Then Mordecai asked them to return this answer to Esther: ‘Don’t think to yourself that you will escape in the king’s house any more than all the Jews. For if you remain silent now, then relief and deliverance will come to the Jews from another place, but you and your father’s house will perish. **Who knows if you haven’t come to the kingdom for such a time as this?**’”

Mordecai tells Esther the truth:

- She can’t hide behind her crown.
- She has a choice—**stay silent**, or **speak up** and risk her life.
He also shows faith: even if Esther stays quiet, God will still send help from somewhere. But she might miss her assignment.

Reflection Question

Where in your life might you be tempted to stay silent when you know God wants you to speak or act?

Bite 2 – Fasting Before the Move, Esther 4:16 (WEB)

“Go, gather together all the Jews who are present in Susa, and **fast for me**, and neither eat nor drink three days, night or day. I also and my maidens will fast in the same way. Then I will go in to the king, which is against the law; and if I perish, I perish.”

Esther doesn’t rush in on her own strength. She:

- Calls for **three days of fasting** (no food, no drink) for all the Jews in the city.
- Joins in the fast with her attendants.
- Decides: “If I perish, I perish.” That’s not drama—that’s surrender.

Reflection Question

What's one situation in your life where you need to **pray and maybe fast** before you make a big move?

Bite 3 – Purpose in the Palace, Esther 8:7–8 (WEB)

“Then King Ahasuerus said to Esther the queen and to Mordecai the Jew, ‘See, I have given Esther the house of Haman, and they have hanged him on the gallows because he laid his hand on the Jews. Write also to the Jews, as it pleases you, in the king’s name, and seal it with the king’s ring; for the writing which is written in the king’s name, and sealed with the king’s ring, may no man reverse.’”

God flips the script:

- The enemy (Haman) is removed.
- Esther and Mordecai are given authority to write a new decree to protect their people.
- The same system that almost killed them is used to **defend** them.

Reflection Question

Have you ever seen God turn something that was supposed to hurt you into something that helped you or others?

Dessert

Esther's story reminds us:

- You're not “just” a backup.
- God can use where you are, even if you didn't choose how you got there.

Reflection Question

Complete this: “God, if You put me **here**, help me to _____.”

To-Go Box

- Your position is not an accident—it can be an **assignment**.
- Fasting and prayer prepare you for scary obedience.
- God can use your “second place” to bring a **first-class** victory for many people.

Write one sentence:

“Lord, help me see my current situation as **purpose**, not just **pressure**.”

Prayer

“Lord, thank You for Esther. Help me not to see myself as ‘second best’ when You call me chosen and placed. Give me courage to obey You even when it scares me, and teach me to pray and fast instead of panicking. Use my life to help others, ‘for such a time as this.’ In Jesus’ name, amen.”

Personal Prayer Space

Write your own short prayer about where you think God has placed you “for such a time as this”:

Activity – Quick Review

Fill in the blanks using what you’ve learned:

1. Esther became queen **instead of** _____.
2. Her cousin who raised her was named _____.
3. Mordecai told her she had come to the kingdom **for such a** _____ **as this**.
4. Before going to the king, Esther asked the Jews to _____ for three days.

Main Course

Bite 1 – Midnight Praise, Acts 16:25 (WEB)

“But about midnight Paul and Silas were praying and singing hymns to God, and the prisoners were listening to them.”

At their worst moment—midnight, in pain, chained—they choose to:

- **Pray**
- **Sing hymns to God**

Everyone else is listening. Their worship turns the prison into a **sanctuary**.

Reflection Question

If someone listened to you in your “midnight moments,” what would they hear—complaints, silence, or praise?

Bite 2 – The Shaking, Acts 16:26–28 (WEB)

²⁶ Suddenly there was a great earthquake, so that the foundations of the prison were shaken; and immediately all the doors were opened and everyone’s bonds were loosened. ²⁷ The jailer, being awakened out of his sleep and seeing the prison doors open, drew his sword and was about to kill himself, supposing that the prisoners had escaped. ²⁸ But Paul cried with a loud voice, saying, “Don’t harm yourself, for we are all here!”

God answers in a wild way:

- Earthquake
- Open doors
- Loose chains

But the first miracle Paul and Silas walk in is **self-control**. They stay, not because they’re stuck, but because they see the jailer’s life is on the line.